

A reading room for papers

Inquiro design reference

Principles, color and type tokens, page composition, and a checklist for keeping the product visually consistent as you build the library, reader, and question flow.

The look comes from a small set of rules applied everywhere, not from extra components. Treat Inquiro as a reading room (paper, ink, margin notes), not as a SaaS landing kit.

Signature of the system: a typeset excerpt, a highlighted passage, and a question in the margin.

1. Product metaphor

The product is find a paper, read it, and ask about a passage. The UI should look like that, not like a marketing site.



Map those verbs onto artifacts: catalog, typeset page, margin note.

Landing vs app

LANDING METAPHOR Excerpt (sample paper) Highlight on a passage Margin question	PRODUCT YOU SHOULD BUILD Paper canvas / PDF Text selection Ask thread on the selection
--	--

Landing shows the full excerpt. Auth only quotes the question so the pages feel related without repeating the composition.

2. Why it reads as considered

Quiet contrast, one accent, and type that matches the subject. Pretty here means restraint, not decoration.

Avoided	Replaced with
Gradient wordmark, giant hero type	Serif headline at a human size (about 4xl / 5xl)
Blue glow, glass, 2rem pills	Hairline borders, radius 0.4rem
Three feature cards, badges, icons	One sequence: Find / Read / Ask
Placeholder marketing copy	Copy about reading and asking the paper
Floating Clerk card on a glow	Split layout, transparent Clerk chrome

3. Design principles

One signature, everything else quiet

The excerpt plus margin question is the showpiece. Headers, buttons, and auth must not compete with it.

Show the product, do not describe it

Prefer a real artifact (page, highlight, citation) over a stock icon grid.

Type carries personality

Serif for titles and paper body. Geist / sans for chrome and buttons. Mono for identifiers (arXiv ids).

Semantic color only

Use background, foreground, muted-foreground, primary, accent, border. Do not add raw Tailwind blues, purples, or a second brand green.

Structure with rules, not cards

Separator and hairline borders are the journal language. A card is for a discrete object (a paper in a list), not for every section.

Hierarchy is vertical, not louder

Kicker, then serif title, then muted body, then one primary button. Do not enlarge type or add a badge to create emphasis.

Motion is optional

Opacity on hover is enough. No looping gradients or spring glows. Respect prefers-reduced-motion.

Copy is interface

Verbs: Find, Read, Ask, Create account, Sign in. No unlock / revolutionize / AI-powered.

4. Tokens (source of truth)

Defined in `src/styles.css` under `:root` and `.dark`. Change tokens there. Do not restyle pages one-off.

Color roles

Token	Role	Do not
background / foreground	Page and body text (archival stone + ink)	Use a second off-white or near-black
primary	The one action (Create account)	Fill large surfaces with green
accent	Selected passage (mark / highlight)	Use as a second brand color for buttons
muted-foreground	Captions, kickers, secondary sentences	Use for primary body copy
border	Structure: 1px rules instead of shadows	Replace with <code>shadow-xl</code> or glass

Approximate light values (oklch in CSS)

Token	oklch	Intent
background	0.978 0.005 102	Uncoated archival paper
foreground	0.235 0.018 52	Ink
primary	0.355 0.058 155	Binding-cloth green
accent	pale green wash	Highlight, not CTA
radius	0.4rem	Tight corners, not pills

Type

Role	Face	Use for
font-serif / font-display	Source Serif 4	Titles, paper body, pull quotes
font-sans	Geist Variable	Nav, buttons, helper text
font-mono	Geist / Menlo	Identifiers such as <code>arXiv:2403.11208</code>

Do not set marketing headlines in Geist. Do not set navigation in serif.

5. Information hierarchy

Reuse this stack on every new screen before inventing layout chrome.

1 Kicker — small, muted, wide tracking
2 Title — serif, tight tracking
3 Body — sans, muted, max about 28-32rem
4 Actions — one primary, rest ghost
5 Meta — mono or extra-small muted

Already used on: landing hero, auth aside, paper excerpt (journal label, title, authors, body, question label).

6. Landing composition

Files: navbar.tsx, hero.tsx, paper-excerpt.tsx, site-footer.tsx. Content width: max-w-6xl.

Header: Logo theme, Sign in (ghost), Create account (primary)
Hero left: kicker, serif H1, one paragraph, CTAs
Hero right: PaperExcerpt (page + highlight + margin Q)
Separator
How you work: Find / Read / Ask as a list, not cards
Separator
Close: one sentence + Create account
Footer colophon

Headline to protect

Read the paper. Ask it back.

Primary action is Create account. Sign in stays ghost / secondary.

7. Sign in and sign up

Shared shell: src/routes/_auth/route.tsx. Clerk widgets in sign-in/\$.tsx and sign-up/\$.tsx. Appearance: src/integrations/clerk/provider.tsx (no card shadow, radius 0.4rem).

DESKTOP ASIDE (LG+) Logo Same kicker language Serif line: Keep the argument... Pull-quote from the excerpt	FORM COLUMN Home (lg+) or Logo (mobile) Theme toggle Clerk form, max-w-md Skeleton while Clerk loads
--	--

On small screens the aside hides. Do not wrap Clerk in another card.

8. Where to change what

Layer	Path	You may change
Color, radius, fonts, shadows	src/styles.css	Tokens only
Buttons, sheet, separator	src/components/ui/*	Variants, not one-off colors
Brand chrome	logo, navbar, site-footer	Keep shared across pages
Product metaphor	paper-excerpt.tsx	Evolve into the real reader
Auth skin	clerk provider + _auth/route	Keep Clerk unboxed

9. Checklist for a new screen

When adding a route, copy hierarchy and tokens, not a whole landing section.

- Does this screen need a new visual idea? Usually no. Reuse kicker / serif title / muted body / hairline / one primary button.
- Is there a real object? Paper row, PDF canvas, highlight, citation: yes. Empty gradient panel: no.
- Colors: only semantic tokens. New meaning (e.g. saved) gets a token in styles.css, not text-emerald-600.
- Type: titles font-serif, UI font-sans, ids font-mono.
- Cards: only if the thing is a list item or a contained document. Page sections get Separator.
- CTAs: one primary per view. Sign in stays ghost.
- Width: marketing max-w-6xl; reading column about 65-72ch; forms max-w-md.
- Dark mode: restyle via tokens. Avoid scattering dark: color overrides.
- shadcn: compose Button, Separator, Sheet, Skeleton. Do not import a glass / purple dashboard kit.
- Motion: none, or opacity/translate on interaction. No ambient loops.

10. Drift to watch for

- rounded-3xl, shadow-xl, or bg-gradient-to-* on new pages
- Inter or Bricolage Grotesque sneaking back in for titles
- Primary used as a large background
- Icon + title + paragraph grids of three
- Clerk (or any vendor) reintroducing a heavy card -- override in clerkAppearance
- Two display typefaces on one page

11. Building the reader

Keep the reader calm: high-readability body, accent only on the active highlight, questions as a narrow margin or sidebar -- not a consumer chat-bubble stack.



If a library page looks like the marketing hero, it is too loud. If the reader looks like the auth form, it is too sparse: give the paper the width and the question the margin.

Working widths and components

Context	Width / component
Site header / landing sections	max-w-6xl, hairline border-b
Reading column	prose measure, roughly 65-72 characters
Auth form	max-w-md, Clerk unboxed
Section breaks	Separator, not Card
Loading Clerk	Skeleton in auth-form-fallback.tsx
Buttons	buttonVariants: default primary, ghost secondary

If this file and the running UI disagree, the running UI plus `src/styles.css` win -- then update this PDF.